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SEPTEMBER 21, 2009 • INDIA TODAY 1

From the editor-in-chief

Since 2003, an extraordinary government-funded collaboration has taken place between seven leading scientific institutions in India. They have been banded together by the Council for Scientific and Industrial Research to discover who or rather what is an Indian.

The Indian Genome Variation Consortium as it is called has conducted the largest-ever study on genetic variations in India on the basis of population. We say India is a diverse nation almost unthinkingly, but the Consortium has been able to prove it to us in a way that will change our understanding of who we are. The study is still on but early findings are dramatic and will have an impact on many fields of human knowledge, not merely genetics. Evolutionary anthropology for one, as well as our understanding of India's ancient history and origins.

Studies by the Consortium and other Indian geneticists seek to prove that India was in fact the first stop of the earliest wave of human migration out of Africa. Andaman islanders, amongst the oldest Indians, are direct descendants of those ancient African migrants 50,000 years ago. Indian geneticists now argue that there may not have been an "Aryan Invasion" that was popularly believed to have changed the course of early Indian history.

Early African migrations saw India become a melting pot of genetic diversity. It is astonishing to learn that inside Indian DNA there are traces of every human race. Before polarising ourselves around linguistic, 'ethnic' and caste groups, we belonged, Indian geneticists believe, to an old family of wanderers.

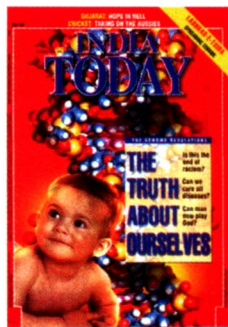
These findings are bound to lead to much debate, because it will shake up many pre-conceived notions, most certainly about the caste hierarchies. But that is not the only purpose of the study. Its primary effect will be felt in the field of pharmacogenetics, which uses knowledge about genomes to find pathways into the origin of illnesses and thereby more effective treatment and cures.

The international Human Genome Project which mapped human DNA in 2001, studied half of the 25,000 genes in our body. The full impact of that knowledge is still being understood. Research into Indian genes will help medicine immeasurably, as it is now established that Indians have a pre-disposition to certain diseases like cardio-vascular conditions. The project fine-tuned this information to see whether there are regional or ethnic variations. They have found that there are.

Environment and lifestyle do play a considerable part in disease patterns, but it is an understanding of our genomes that will help us manage the diseases and come up with cost-effective ways of adapting modern health technology for our specific purposes.

Our cover story this week was written by Managing Editor Raj Chengappa who says, "The information unearthed by the Indian genome studies must be used with caution and with strict privacy rules so as to avoid unscientific profiling and stereotyping." As fascinating as its evolutionary findings are, the database of Indian genetic types built by the study must always primarily serve science, medicine and public health. The outcome of this project has great potential and hopefully, it would help to improve the quality of life for all Indians in time to come.

(Aroon Purie)



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